

burden rather than a new challenge. You feel like a cheerleader with your team losing 63 to 7 in the fourth quarter.

Most of us respond by redoubling our efforts. Instead of telling our job "goodbye, *ciao*, it was fun while it lasted," we put our heads down and dig. We figure the job bores us because we're not giving it enough. That's like saying the milk went sour because we didn't tell it we loved it.

Jokes about reaching midlife crisis are funny but they're also uniformly bleak. Dean Martin says you drink so much that falling in the street is the only time you get any rest. Your cufflinks double as curb feelers. Your idea of the great outdoors is playing bridge in a smoky room with the window open half an inch. You decide to discuss the facts of life with your teenager and he starts with, "Sure, what would you like to know?"

Midlife crisis, with different names, has been around for centuries. Grandpa and grandma got restless too. What's new in the 1980s is not the crisis but the wealth that offers young people a way out of it. The Census Bureau reports that the real net worth of U.S. households has *tripled* during the past thirty-five years. For the first time in history, millions of young Americans own a home, a couple of cars, and have money in the bank. For those millions, very early retirement is a viable way out of the pain of midlife crisis.

If you have a modest nest egg, you can opt for bare-bones retirement. Chapter 11 tells how to make it work. If you have a slightly bigger stash, say \$200,000 or \$300,000, you can retire well. If you have \$400,000 or \$500,000, like I did, you can retire with class. And if you're lucky enough to have millions, like my friend Big Bill, you can retire to a life of luxury.

THE MAGNATE WHO QUIT

Big Bill is an insurance magnate. He's shrewd, cautious, hard-driving, quick to analyze people, and a terror when he's mad. He spent the first twenty years of his adult life in